NYKAA

User Experience Analysis

A descriptive teardown of five real journeys, three user conversations, and what I took away from it.

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TAG INDEX

Smooth Slow Confusing Frustrating

SECTION 1

What this tear down covers

I went through the app like a real shopper, poking at everything rather than running one clean checkout. Across the session I ended up taking five distinct journeys. Each one below is broken into the actual steps I took, tagged by how it felt, with what I was trying to do and what worked or didn't, then closed with my own opinion and a fix.

Journey 1 —First-time login & checking offers. Testing onboarding friction and the homepage.

Journey 2 — Finding a sunscreen for oily skin. Testing manual category navigation and filter logic.

Journey 3 — Ordering a Cetaphil face wash. Testing direct search, product clarity and checkout.

Journey 4 — Nykaa Play (content & discovery). Testing the video-feed-to-commerce link.

Journey 5 — Accounts & Wallet (post-purchase & loyalty). Testing trust signals, refunds and rewards.

SECTION 2

Journey Breakdowns

Journey 1 First-time login & checking offers

Goal: get into the app as a brand-new user and see what deals are running before I commit to anything.

1 Login & OTP SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Get into the app as fast as possible.

What worked well:

Logging in was quick. Google, Email and Apple were all offered, I entered my mobile number, and the OTP filled in on its own from the message. There was nothing to think about, which made it the smoothest part of the whole app.

2 Profile Prompt SLOW

What I was trying to do:

Reach the app and just start looking around.

What didn't work well:

The moment I was in, a "Help us know you better" pop-up asked for my name and email. I hadn't even seen a single product yet, so I just crossed it. It's a small thing on its own, but it sits between me and the app right at the start.

3 Notification Alert SLOW

What I was trying to do:

Get past the prompts and onto the home screen.

What didn't work well:

Right after crossing the first pop-up, a "Don't miss out" notification prompt appeared, and there was no easy way to close it. So now it's a second interruption before I've done anything at all, and it quietly nudges you into saying yes just to move on.

4 Ad Pop-Up FRUSTRATING

What I was trying to do:

Finally start browsing the catalog.

What didn't work well:

Right after that, a full-screen Rare Beauty ad opened and then parked itself on the side of the screen. That was the third interruption in a row, and by this point I was just trying to get rid of things instead of actually exploring.

5 Homescreen CONFUSING

What I was trying to do:

Orient myself and figure out where to begin.

What didn't work well:

The home screen was loud and far too vibrant, with so many colours and campaigns competing at once that I genuinely didn't know where to look or where to start from. The leftover ad was still eating into the screen too, so it felt less like a starting point and more like a billboard shouting at me.

6 Offer page SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

See what sales were running without getting pulled in ten directions.

What worked well:

The Offers page, by contrast, was actually well done. The monthly sale, trending items and bestsellers were all split neatly by category, so it was easy to scan and understand. This was the app showing it can be organised when it wants to be.

Clear Opinion : Bad (entry), Good (offers)

The login itself is genuinely good, but everything after it is a wall of pop-ups and ads before I can even see what Nykaa sells. By the time I reached the home screen I was already tired of closing things, and the screen was too loud to make sense of. The Offers page is the opposite, clean and easy. The design isn't the problem here, it's the marketing layer piled in front of it at the worst possible moment.

Recommendation: Hold the profile and notification prompts until after the first browse, put a clear close button on every pop-up, and stop the entry ad from blocking the home screen so it can load clean.

Journey 2 : Finding a sunscreen for oily skin

Goal: find a budget-friendly sunscreen from a brand I trust, suited to oily skin, by navigating the menus rather than searching.

1 Category navigation FRUSTRATING

What I was trying to do:

Reach the face sunscreen section manually through the menus.

What didn't work well:

I wanted something suited to oily skin, so I started by exploring the Category option, expecting it to take me somewhere useful. Instead it just led me back into Categories again, and tapping through opened yet another dropdown. The actual path was Category → Categories → Skin → Sun Care → Face Sunscreen, so I was four steps deep before a single sunscreen even showed up. Going down it level by level felt slow and frustrating for something this simple.

2 Product Search CONFUSING

What I was trying to do:

Narrow the page down to sunscreens for my skin type.

What didn't work well:

The shop page led with "Shop by Formulation," but not "Shop by Skin Type," which is the one thing I had actually come in looking for. So the page was offering me the wrong way to start narrowing things down, and I had to dig further instead of being met where I was.

3 Skin-concern quiz SLOW

What I was trying to do:

Let the app personalise the results to oily skin.

What didn't work well:

I scrolled down and found a small quiz, picked oiliness, and hit view recommendations. I genuinely liked being asked, but I expected the whole page to re-rank for oily skin afterwards. Instead it only updated a few products inside that same tiny section. The personalisation stayed boxed into one small tile rather than changing what I was actually looking at.

4 Apply "Oily" filter SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Filter the listing down to products meant for oily skin.

What worked well:

The filter page was really well crafted. I set it to oily, applied it, and could finally see products meant for my oily skin instead of a generic mix. After all the navigation hassle, this is where it clicked for me and the journey started feeling worthwhile.

5 Product page SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Check whether the product was actually right for me.

What worked well:

I opened a brand I recognised and the page was clear and well laid out. Everything I needed was easy to find, and it felt trustworthy rather than cluttered.

6 AI Summarized Reviews SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Decide quickly without reading hundreds of reviews.

What worked well:

The AI-summarised reviews were the best part of the whole journey. They told me what I needed to know fast, pulling the real pros and cons together, and that is exactly what made me decide to order. This single feature carried the journey.

Clear Opinion — Bad (navigation), Good (product page)

Navigation is the weakest part of this journey. The Category menu is misleading, since tapping Category just opens another Category, then more dropdowns, and going four steps deep is slow and frustrating, especially as users often don't know exactly what they want yet. The filters felt incomplete too, with no Shop by Skin Type offered up front. What saved the whole thing was the product page, and the AI review summary in particular, which is genuinely excellent and is what closed the sale for me.

Recommendation: Flatten the Category menu so it doesn't loop, make products reachable in one or two taps, and offer all filters including skin type up front. The quiz should actually add value by refreshing the full results page, not sit there as a distraction or a waste of time.

Journey 3 — Ordering a Cetaphil face wash

Goal: I roughly know what I want, so I go straight to search, pick the product, and try to buy it quickly.

1 Search & autocomplete SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Find a specific face wash without browsing.

What worked well:

I typed "face" and the search instantly suggested "face wash." It understood what I wanted right away, which made starting effortless and confirmed the app was on the same page as me.

2 Product page SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Pick the right version for my skin.

What worked well:

The product page was clear. It showed two versions, one for all skin types and one for dry, and I could tell them apart and pick easily without second-guessing.

3 Select size variant SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Choose the size that fit my budget.

What worked well:

Choosing the size was simple. The options were easy to read and select, with no guesswork about what I was picking.

4 In the Bag FRUSTRATING

What I was trying to do:

Add the item and move towards checkout.

What didn't work well:

Adding to the bag only gave a small toast at the bottom and no clear way forward, so I had to go back and tap the bag icon myself. Right at the moment I was ready to buy, the app left me without an obvious next step.

5 Coupons & Offers FRUSTRATING

What I was trying to do:

Find a discount I could actually use.

What didn't work well:

Inside the coupons, the only one available told me to shop for two more items, which is useless on a first order where I only wanted one thing. It felt like the offer existed to push me to spend more rather than to actually help me.

6 Reward Points SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Bring the price down before paying.

What worked well:

The saving grace here was the reward points sitting in my account, auto-credited and ready to use. That felt like a genuine win at checkout and softened the disappointment from the coupons.

Clear Opinion : Mixed (great discovery, leaky checkout)

Discovery is the best part of the app. Search, the product page and the size choice were all quick and clear. The checkout leaks a little, though. Adding to the bag gave no clear path forward, and the only coupon needed more spending to work. The auto-credited reward points are the one real bright spot, and they almost make up for it.

Recommendation: After Add to Bag, show a clear "Go to Bag" action, and offer coupons a first-time buyer can actually use instead of ones that force more spending. Keep the reward points exactly as they are, and showcase their perks more.

Journey 4 : Nykaa Play (content & discovery)

Goal: explore the app's video content to find real-world reviews and tutorials for inspiration before buying.

1 Accessing Nykaa Play SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

Watch beauty content to get some purchase ideas.

What worked well:

Tapping the "Play" button on the bottom menu loaded a short-video feed almost instantly. The interface is familiar and works smoothly, much like Instagram Reels or YouTube Shorts, so there was no learning curve at all.

2 Searching for specific content FRUSTRATING

What I was trying to do:

Find a video showing a real-world swatch of a product I was interested in.

What didn't work well:

When I searched for specific shade swatches, the results were completely irrelevant. Instead of the exact product in action, I was shown random makeup tutorials and creamy foundation ads. The content simply did not map to my search intent, so the feature couldn't help me at the one moment I actually needed it.

3 The content-to-commerce loop CONFUSING

What I was trying to do:

Buy a product featured in one of the videos.

What didn't work well:

Sometimes a video showed a great look, but there was no clear, single-click pathway to add the exact variant shown to my bag. The content and the shopping felt like two separate worlds, so the inspiration never turned into an easy purchase.

Clear Opinion Bad

A video feed is a great idea for a beauty app, but it fails exactly when the user needs it most, which is for visual validation. If I search for a specific shade to build confidence and the app shows me a generic makeup ad instead, it breaks trust and makes the whole feature feel useless rather than helpful.

Recommendation: Tie the Nykaa Play search directly to the product catalog. When a user searches for a specific shade, show only user-generated content or official swatches of that exact product, with a direct "Add to Bag" button overlaid on the video so inspiration leads straight to purchase.

Journey 5 — Accounts & Wallet (post-purchase & loyalty)

Goal: check my membership status, wallet balance, and understand how the loyalty rewards actually work.

1 Account dashboard SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

See my profile details and order history.

What worked well:

The account section is genuinely clean. Orders, wallet and profile details are spaced out nicely, completely free of the visual clutter that makes the homepage so loud. It was a relief to land somewhere calm in the app.

2 Checking the Nykaa Wallet SMOOTH

What I was trying to do:

See if I had usable funds or instant-refund options.

What worked well:

The wallet instantly showed my auto-credited reward points, and it clearly highlighted instant-refund options. Seeing both up front builds real trust for any future purchase, because I know my money and rewards are visible and within reach.

3 Understanding Nykaa Prive SLOW

What I was trying to do:

Figure out how to move up a membership tier for better discounts.

What didn't work well:

Tapping into the Privé loyalty program opened a very text-heavy page explaining the tiers. Working out exactly how much more I needed to spend to reach the next level meant reading through too much small print, when a simple visual would have told me at a glance.

Clear Opinion — Good (with a caveat)

The wallet and refund setup is excellent and builds long-term reliability, because I always know where my money and points stand. The loyalty program itself, though, feels like reading a terms-and-conditions document rather than an engaging reward system, and that buries something that should feel exciting.

Recommendation: Make the Privé dashboard more visual. Instead of walls of text, use a clear progress bar, something like "Spend ₹500 more to unlock the next tier," so the loyalty loop feels rewarding and motivating rather than like a contract.

SECTION 3

External User Perspectives

I spoke casually to three people who use Nykaa but aren't from a product or design background, to hear how they actually experience the app, what they like, what frustrates them, and what makes them close it without buying. Their views often differed from mine, which is the real value of asking.

Anjali Gupta Finance background

Uses Nykaa for cosmetics and tracking trends.

Likes: The theme of the app is really good and keeps her updated on the latest trends. For makeup, Nykaa is the first name that comes to her mind, so it has strong top-of-mind recall for her.

Dislikes: She finds the products fairly expensive, so she tends to open the app "when she's feeling rich." Her bigger problem is shades, because most cosmetic shades look very similar on screen and she can't tell them apart, whereas in a store the shades clearly look different when she's buying.

Drops off when: She gets confused between similar products and offers, which all look good, and can't decide which is best. So she ends up closing the app and procrastinating the order, preferring to check the price and feel in a store, and maybe coming back later only if she feels like ordering.

Shivam Thakur Engineering background

Uses Nykaa mostly for gifting.

Likes: When he's gifting his girlfriend, the app gives him a wide variety of gift options. For someone who doesn't know what a girl might like, the gift sets and curation do the heavy lifting for him.

Dislikes: He's usually low on pocket, so the discounts feel small, and the offers push him to buy more when he only wants one specific thing. He also finds the app very women-centric, and the heavily pink branding makes him a little shy to order, even though skincare is common to everyone.

Drops off when: Looking for something for himself, he researches and compares prices on other websites. The moment he finds a cheaper standalone option elsewhere, he leaves Nykaa and orders there instead.

Surbhi Thakur Banking background

A frequent, highly engaged shopper with a liking for premium brands.

Likes: She sees Nykaa as a reliable source and loves the access to top brands. As a frequent orderer she really values the point system and the membership perks, which give her a sense of being looked after.

Dislikes: The advertising bombardment. She sees the same Nykaa ads everywhere, on Google, in WhatsApp, and in text messages, and that constant retargeting becomes frustrating and tiring for someone who already shops there often.

Drops off when: She's looking for faster delivery, but the delivery time is often long, and sometimes her favourite products are out of stock. She ends up waiting for an offer or a restock and simply doesn't complete the purchase.

SECTION 4

My Reflections & Perspective Change

What did I notice that I usually ignore?

Normally I move through an app fast and skip the small things, the pop-ups, the banners, the number of taps it takes to get somewhere. Doing this slowly, I noticed how hard the app works to pull my attention before I've done anything at all. The pop-ups, the notification prompts and the ads were stacked one after another, and the homepage was so loud and colourful that it was hard to settle on where to look. It was so strong that there were moments I genuinely forgot I had only come to buy a sunscreen, and that is exactly the kind of thing I'd normally swipe past without a second thought. Once I started counting the steps and noticing the noise, I couldn't unsee how much of the experience is built to channel me into ads and offers rather than to my goal.

Did my perspective change after talking to users?

Yes, mostly about loyalty. Before talking to people I assumed a big catalog and a nice-looking app were enough to keep users. But what I heard was that people aren't loyal to the app, they're loyal to whatever is convenient for them. Anjali opens it to check trends, Shivam only uses it to gift his girlfriend, and Arshiya, even as a premium buyer, is ready to leave over ads and slow delivery. Everyone has their own way of using it, and the other ways simply don't matter to them. People are also fast and impatient. They either decide the app is confusing and drop off, or they get pulled into casual scrolling and lose track of what they came for, or they get so caught up in the ads and offers that they forget the actual item. And for someone with a specific need or a tight budget, the hesitation only grows, because what they see online can be hard to trust against what they'd actually get offline. That gap between the screen and real life is where a lot of people quietly give up.

What did I find most challenging?

Patience, honestly. I've never spent this much time just looking at one app. I had a clear goal, but I also had to explore every possible way of reaching the product, through the homepage, the categories, the offers and the search, and that constant wandering made me restless. My natural instinct is to hit the search bar, find the item and check out, so forcing myself to go down the broken category trees and sit with the irrelevant filters instead of skipping them took real discipline. It also made me realise how exhausting a poorly optimised discovery flow can be for an ordinary user who doesn't have the patience or the habit of pushing through it, and who would simply leave.

Descriptive companion document to the five-slide presentation. Text-forward by design; the visual walkthrough lives in the slide deck.